to be taken into account when we take up with the Communist regime, the question of recognition.' [22] The government was also aware of China's pre-conditions for the establishment of diplomatic relations. It was logical for India, too, to lay down its requirements as part of the negotiation. [23]

However, eventually, this did not happen. Within the Government of India, there were two views about discussing the status of Tibet with the Chinese. There were those who felt that such a discussion could re-open the whole question about whether Tibet was independent or a part of China, and call into doubt the agreement between British India and Tibet on the McMahon Line. Panikkar weighed in on this debate by saying that since the Chinese had not raised this matter with the Indian side, it was prudent to proceed on the assumption that the new regime did not intend to rake up the historical past of India's northern frontier. Nehru was persuaded by this line of reasoning. And so, by November 1949, instead of focusing on identifying tangible demands for the Chinese side to meet, the Government of India turned the whole debate on recognition of the new Chinese regime into a question of timing. In his note to Bajpai on 17 November 1949, Nehru declared, 'It is clear that recognition has to be given. The only question that arises is that of timing. In regard to timing also there are limitations at either end.' [24]

What happened to make the timing of the recognition dependent not upon securing national priorities but on the calendar? There was more than one reason for this. Foremost among them was that the formal establishment of the People's Republic of China on 1 October 1949 made the question of recognition time-sensitive. Nehru had always felt that India should recognize Communist China as early as possible as this would give it some leverage in building strong relations with the country. He grew anxious over the possibility of the British